that (a) our exponentiating technology has reached the precipice of self-destruction, but also the first time that (b) we can postpone or avoid destruction by going somewhere else, somewhere off the Earth.

These two clusters of capabilities, (a) and (b), make our time extraordinary in directly contradictory ways—which both (a) strengthen and (b) weaken Gott's argument. I don't know how to predict whether the new destructive technologies will hasten, more than the new spaceflight technologies will delay, human extinction. But since never before have we contrived the means of annihilating ourselves, and never before have we developed the technology for settling other worlds, I think a compelling case can be made that our time is extraordinary precisely in the context of Gott's argument. If this is true, it significantly increases the margin of error in such estimates of future longevity. The worst is worse, and the best better: Our short-term prospects are even bleaker and—if we can survive the short term—our long-term chances even brighter than Gott calculates.

But the former is no more cause for despair than the latter is for complacency. Nothing forces us to be passive observers, clucking in dismay as our destiny inexorably works itself out. If we cannot quite seize fate by the neck, perhaps we can misdirect it, or mollify it, or escape it.

Of course we must keep our planet habitable—not on a leisurely timescale of centuries or millennia, but urgently, on a timescale of decades or even years. This will involve changes in government, in industry, in ethics, in economics, and in religion. We've never done such a thing before, certainly not on a global scale. It may be too difficult for us. Dangerous technologies may be too widespread. Corruption may be too pervasive. Too many leaders may be focused on the short term rather than the long. There may be too many quarreling ethnic groups, nation-states, and ideologies for the right kind of global change to be instituted. We may be too foolish to perceive even what the real dangers are, or that much of what we hear about them is determined by those with a vested interest in minimizing fundamental change.